

Perceived Stress Scale

The Perceived Stress Scale (PSS) is a classic stress assessment instrument that helps us understand how different situations affect our feelings and our perceived stress. The questions in this scale ask about your feelings and thoughts during the last month. In each case, you will be asked to indicate how often you felt or thought a certain way. Although some of the questions are similar, there are differences between them, and you should treat each one as a separate question. The best approach is to answer quickly. That is, do not try to count the number of times you felt a particular way; rather indicate the alternative that seems like a reasonable estimate.

For each question, chose from the following:

0 = Never 1 = Almost Never 2 = Sometimes 3 = Fairly Often 4 = Very Often

- _____ 1. In the last month, how often have you been upset because of something that happened unexpectedly?
- _____ 2. In the last month, how often have you felt that you were unable to control the important things in your life?
- _____ 3. In the last month, how often have you felt nervous and stressed?
- _____ 4. In the last month, how often have you felt confident about your ability to handle your personal problems?
- _____ 5. In the last month, how often have you felt that things were going your way?
- _____ 6. In the last month, how often have you found that you could not cope with all the things you have had to do?
- _____ 7. In the last month, how often have you been able to control irritations in your life?
- _____ 8. In the last month, how often have you felt that you were on top of things?
- _____ 9. In the last month, how often have you been angered because of things that happened that were outside of your control?
- _____ 10. In the last month, how often have you felt difficulties were piling up so high that you could not overcome them?

Determining the PSS Score

1. Reverse the scores for questions 4, 5, 7, and 8. On these 4 questions, change the scores like this:
0 = 4, 1 = 3, 2 = 2, 3 = 1, 4 = 0.
2. Add up the scores for each item to get a total. Total score is _____.
3. Individual scores on the PSS can range from 0 to 40 with higher scores indicating higher perceived stress.
 - Scores ranging from 0-13 would be considered low stress.
 - Scores ranging from 14-26 would be considered moderate stress.
 - Scores ranging from 27-40 would be considered high perceived stress.